purchase a steamer to sail between Madras and Rangoon. Unable to find the addressee, the Burma police opened the letter and passed it on to the Madras police.[106] Evidently, SSNCo attracted a wide range of persons—from committed volunteers fired by idealism to oddballs.

In August 1907, one Nainar Pillai came to Burma from Tuticorin on a mission to sell shares. Employed as a clerk at SSNCo, his father had been an accountant at BI before resigning his position to join SSNCo as an agent at Colombo. According to a report by the Burma police, Nainar Pillai succeeded in selling some fifty shares, and planned to spend a few more months travelling across Burma to canvass for further subscriptions.[107]

Twenty persons in Thiruvavaduthurai—the location of arguably the most respected Saiva monastery—according to a police report, had taken ninety-one shares. Fourteen of them were said to be Vellalars, the dominant non-Brahmin community.[108]

The evidence that we have been able to gather indicates that the investors came mostly from Madras Presidency. Bharati's comment that SSNCo was reliant on the enterprise of Tuticorin patriots and the capital of the Bengalis is not borne out by the fragmentary, if fairly extensive, evidence that has been unearthed.[109]

Apart from the overwhelming support by such well-meaning and patriotic people, SSNCo may have attracted some less than scrupulous people as well. In any case, SSNCo had inspired people to believe that running a shipping company was within the realm of possibility and was not the monopoly of Europeans.



What was the ideology of those who invested in SSNCo? Were they all firebrand nationalists? William S. Meyer, chief secretary to Government of Madras, observed that 'a number of persons who are in no way seditionists, or even extremists, took shares in this Company [SSNCo.]—the Hon'ble Mr N. Subba Rao, for instance, Member of the Viceregal Legislative Council.'[110] Certainly, in the initial stages, many patriotic people subscribed